

IE Ireland (IE) — Document Registry

Health Education System: Social, Personal and Health Education (SPHE)

Bioregion: Atlantic / Island

Reform Status: Ongoing reform (Junior Cycle 2023, Senior Cycle 2024, Primary 2025)

This registry lists all source documents identified for Ireland in the OneHealth EU project. Documents are grouped by category. Each entry includes: a short description, document type, year, and a link to the download page or direct URL.

System Overview

Ireland has one of the most developed health education systems in the EU. The subject **SPHE** (Social, Personal and Health Education) is **mandatory** at all levels: Primary, Junior Cycle (post-primary, Years 1–3), and Senior Cycle (post-primary, Years 5–6). The system is grounded in a holistic understanding of health (physical, mental, social, spiritual) and a rights-based approach. Reforms undertaken between 2022 and 2025 significantly expanded the scope and contact hours of SPHE.

A. Primary Legislation

1. Education Act 1998 (as amended)

- **Type:** Primary legislation
 - **Year:** 1998 (with subsequent amendments)
 - **Publisher:** Oireachtas (Irish Parliament)
 - **Description:** The foundational statute governing the Irish education system. Establishes the NCCA (National Council for Curriculum and Assessment), defines the rights of parents and schools, including the parental right to opt out of SPHE content that conflicts with their moral or religious convictions. Provides the legal basis for curriculum development.
 - **Access page:** <https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/1998/act/51/enacted/en/html>
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2. Education Welfare Act 2000

- **Type:** Primary legislation
 - **Year:** 2000
 - **Publisher:** Oireachtas
 - **Description:** Regulates compulsory schooling and attendance (ages 6–16). Provides the legal context for the mandatory status of SPHE and related wellbeing programmes.
 - **Access page:** <https://www.irishstatutebook.ie/eli/2000/act/22/enacted/en/html>
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B. Curriculum Specifications

3. Junior Cycle SPHE Specification (2023)

- **Type:** Curriculum specification
 - **Year:** 2023 (mandatory implementation from September 2023)
 - **Publisher:** National Council for Curriculum and Assessment (NCCA) / curriculumonline.ie
 - **Level:** Post-primary, Junior Cycle (Years 1–3, ages 12–15)
 - **Description:** The updated SPHE specification for Junior Cycle, replacing the previous 2000 specification. Expanded to **100 hours** across 3 years (up from 70 hours). Structured around four strands: (1) Understanding Myself and Others, (2) Making Healthy Choices, (3) Relationships and Sexuality, (4) Emotional Wellbeing. RSE (Relationships and Sexuality Education) is fully integrated as Strand 3. No terminal examination — assessment is formative and classroom-based.
 - **Specification page (NCCA):** <https://ncca.ie/en/junior-cycle/junior-cycle-subjects/sphe/>
 - **Curriculum Online (specification + materials):** <https://www.curriculumonline.ie/junior-cycle/junior-cycle-subjects/sphe/>
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4. Senior Cycle SPHE Specification (2024)

- **Type:** Curriculum specification
 - **Year:** Published September 2024; mandatory for LCA: September 2025; mandatory for Leaving Cert Established: September 2027
 - **Publisher:** NCCA / curriculumonline.ie
 - **Level:** Post-primary, Senior Cycle (Years 5–6, ages 15–18)
 - **Description:** The first unified and comprehensive SPHE specification for Senior Cycle — prior to 2024, no consistent programme existed at this level. **60 hours** across 2 years. Three strands: (1) Health and Wellbeing, (2) Relationships and Sexuality, (3) Into Adulthood. Three cross-cutting elements: thinking critically and empathetically, exercising rights and responsibilities, being health literate. Not examined in the Leaving Certificate.
 - **Specification page (NCCA):** <https://ncca.ie/en/senior-cycle/senior-cycle-subjects-and-short-courses/sphe/>
 - **Curriculum Online:** <https://www.curriculumonline.ie/senior-cycle/senior-cycle-subjects/sphe/>
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5. Primary Curriculum Framework (2023)

- **Type:** Curriculum framework
- **Year:** 2023 (published); phased rollout from 2025/26
- **Publisher:** NCCA
- **Level:** Primary (Junior Infants – 6th Class, ages 4–12)
- **Description:** The new overarching curriculum framework for primary schools. SPHE and Physical Education (PE) are merged into a single **Wellbeing** curriculum area. Schools are required to adopt Wellbeing as one of the first three curriculum areas to implement in the rollout phase (from 2025/26).

- **Access page:** <https://ncca.ie/en/primary/primary-curriculum-framework/>
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6. Framework for Junior Cycle 2015

- **Type:** Policy framework / Curriculum framework
 - **Year:** 2015
 - **Publisher:** Department of Education Ireland (DES)
 - **Description:** The Junior Cycle reform document that established **Wellbeing** as one of four key pillars of Junior Cycle education. Introduced the Wellbeing Programme (400 hours across 3 years), delivered through SPHE (100h), CSPE (100h), PE (100h), and additional school-designed wellbeing components (100h). The foundational document for the current shape of SPHE at Junior Cycle.
 - **Access page + PDF:** <https://www.gov.ie/en/publication/83d7a-framework-for-junior-cycle-2015/>
 - **Direct PDF:** <https://assets.gov.ie/24999/ded3c3db879a421c86dca19de69eb7ee.pdf>
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C. Policy Documents and Guidelines

7. Wellbeing Policy Statement and Framework for Practice 2018–2023

- **Type:** Policy document
 - **Year:** 2018
 - **Publisher:** Department of Education and Skills (DES)
 - **Level:** Post-primary
 - **Description:** The comprehensive wellbeing policy for post-primary schools. Defines six student wellbeing indicators (Active, Responsible, Connected, Resilient, Respected, Aware). Establishes the whole-school approach to wellbeing across four domains: Culture and Environment, Curriculum, Relationships and Partnerships, Policy and Planning. Directly informs the SPHE programme and its broader school context.
 - **Direct PDF:** <https://assets.gov.ie/25111/35c956d4d15a41e4a82ccd36ce37db4b.pdf>
 - **Access page:** <https://www.gov.ie/en/publication/wellbeing-policy-statement-and-framework-for-practice/>
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8. RSE Guidance for Schools (2023 update)

- **Type:** Guidance document
- **Year:** 2023
- **Publisher:** Department of Education Ireland
- **Description:** Updated guidance for schools on delivering RSE (Relationships and Sexuality Education) as an integral component of SPHE. Addresses parental opt-out rights, the ethos dimension, age-appropriate content frameworks, and safe messaging requirements. Key document for understanding the public debate around SPHE in Ireland.

- **Access page (SPHE/RSE):** <https://www.gov.ie/en/policy-information/e5b69-sphe/>
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9. Junior Cycle Wellbeing Guidelines (NCCA, 2017)

- **Type:** Guidelines
 - **Year:** 2017
 - **Publisher:** NCCA
 - **Description:** NCCA guidance for implementing the Wellbeing Programme at Junior Cycle. Describes the structure of the 400-hour Wellbeing Programme, the role of SPHE, CSPE and PE within it, and practical guidance for schools on timetabling and school self-evaluation (SSE) for wellbeing.
 - **Access page:** <https://ncca.ie/en/junior-cycle/wellbeing/>
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10. Senior Cycle Redevelopment — Overview and Reform Documents (2022–ongoing)

- **Type:** Policy reform documents
 - **Year:** 2022 (announced); ongoing implementation
 - **Publisher:** Department of Education Ireland
 - **Description:** A suite of documents underpinning the broader Senior Cycle reform programme. Defines seven key competencies for Senior Cycle, including **Cultivating Wellbeing** (the competency central to SPHE). Provides the policy rationale for making Senior Cycle SPHE mandatory from 2025/2027.
 - **Access page:** <https://www.gov.ie/en/policy-information/senior-cycle/>
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D. Teacher Support Resources (Oide)

11. Oide SPHE — Junior Cycle Teacher Resources

- **Type:** Teacher support / Professional development resources
 - **Year:** 2023 – present
 - **Publisher:** Oide (Professional Development Service for Teachers)
 - **Description:** Online platform providing professional support for teachers delivering Junior Cycle SPHE. Includes lesson plans, strand-specific materials, exemplar tasks, safe messaging guidance, online courses, and cluster group support. Oide was formed in 2022 from the merger of PDST, JCT and other services.
 - **Access page:** <https://oide.ie/post-primary/home/wellbeing/sphe-junior-cycle/>
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12. Oide SPHE — Senior Cycle Teacher Resources

- **Type:** Teacher support / Professional development resources
- **Year:** 2024 – present

- **Publisher:** Oide
 - **Description:** Support materials for teachers implementing the new 2024 Senior Cycle SPHE specification. Particular focus on Strand 2 (Relationships and Sexuality) as the most complex delivery area. Includes online modules, introductory workshops, and in-school cluster visit support.
 - **Access page:** <https://oide.ie/post-primary/home/wellbeing/sphe-senior-cycle/>
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E. Research Reports and Data

13. HBSC Ireland 2022 — Health Behaviour in School-aged Children

- **Type:** Research report
 - **Year:** 2022
 - **Publisher:** University of Galway (in partnership with WHO)
 - **Description:** The Irish edition of the international HBSC study. A key empirical document — findings (including that nearly 50% of Irish teenagers report low mood) provided a direct evidence base for the 2024 Senior Cycle SPHE reform. Covers health, wellbeing, risk behaviours, and the social environment of children and young people in Ireland. New topics in the 2022 edition include loneliness, menstrual health, and the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic. A Trends Report (1998–2022) is also available.
 - **Access page + downloads:** <https://www.universityofgalway.ie/hbsc/>
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F. Supporting Organisations and Public Health Resources

14. HSE — Healthy Ireland Framework 2019–2025

- **Type:** National health strategy
 - **Year:** 2019 (updated 2024)
 - **Publisher:** Department of Health Ireland / Health Service Executive (HSE)
 - **Description:** The national public health strategy to which SPHE directly refers. Defines public health priorities (mental health, physical activity, addiction prevention) that align with SPHE programme goals at school level.
 - **Access page (HSE):** <https://www.hse.ie/eng/about/who/healthyireland/>
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15. Safe Messaging Guidelines — Suicide and Self-Harm (HSE / NOSP, 2022)

- **Type:** Clinical guidelines
- **Year:** 2022
- **Publisher:** HSE / National Office for Suicide Prevention (NOSP)
- **Description:** Safe messaging guidelines for communicating about suicide and self-harm. Embedded in both the Junior Cycle (Strand 4: Emotional Wellbeing) and Senior Cycle SPHE

specifications — SPHE teachers are required to follow these guidelines. A mandatory reference for schools addressing mental health topics.

- **Access page:** <https://www.nosp.ie/resources/safe-messaging/>

G. Analytical Files in Project Repository (NotebookLM)

The following analytical documents were prepared for this project, based on the sources listed above:

File	Contents
IE_SPHE_Akt_Prawny_Kontekst_Legislacyjny.md	Legal and historical context of SPHE — from 1999 to 2025; key acts, policies, reform timeline
IE_SPHE_Curriculum_Junior_Cycle_2023.md	Full analysis of the Junior Cycle 2023 specification — 4 strands, learning outcomes, assessment, comparison with the 2000 programme
IE_SPHE_Curriculum_Senior_Cycle_2024.md	Full analysis of the Senior Cycle 2024 specification — 3 strands, cross-cutting elements, connection to the Senior Cycle Redevelopment
IE_SPHE_Metodyka_Wellbeing_Framework.md	SPHE teaching methodology, Junior Cycle Wellbeing Programme (400h), 6 wellbeing indicators, supporting organisations
IE_SPHE_FAQ_Kontekst_Porownanie_PL_2025.md	FAQ and comparison of Irish SPHE with Polish health education (context for the OneHealth EU project)

Registry compiled: 2026-05-29

Project: OneHealth EU — Comparative Analysis of Health Education in EU Countries

Last link verification: May 2026